

RTFCLMGZN

SOLO FOUNDER REVENUE PLAYBOOK

A simple, practical plan for turning the newsboard, magazines,
and automated newsroom into income.

Built for one person. No sales team. No giant traffic assumptions.

The answer in one sentence

Use free AI and technology news to attract people, then make money from companies that want access to those readers, products readers already want to buy, and a small premium product worth paying for every month.

The rule

Do not try to monetize everything at once. Build three revenue engines in order: (1) sponsors, (2) affiliate recommendations, and (3) a paid magazine + intelligence membership.

1. Where the money will actually come from

There are only four groups that can pay you. Focus on the first three now.

Who pays	Why they pay	What you sell	Timing
Technology companies	Exposure to readers, product launches, brand credibility	Newsletter sponsor, magazine sponsor, launch package	Start now
Readers buying products	Help choosing AI tools, software, PCs, components and gadgets	Affiliate commission from recommendations	Start now
Loyal readers	A useful premium briefing and magazine, not ordinary news	Monthly or annual membership	Launch after the product exists
Recruiters / B2B clients	Job candidates, research, trend reports and visibility	Job listings, directories, custom briefs	Add later

Your best model

A free newsboard supported by direct sponsors and affiliate commerce, with a \$4.99/month premium layer built around the magazine, daily intelligence and alerts.

Do not make ordinary news the paid product.

- Breaking news, normal articles and the homepage stay free. They create reach, repeat visits and search/social traffic.
- Paid members receive convenience and utility: premium magazines, a concise daily intelligence brief, audio, alerts, archive access and fewer ads.
- This mirrors a practical freemium pattern used by established technology publishers: keep core news free, then charge for premium reporting, newsletters and a better experience.

Revenue priority for a one-man operation

Rank	Engine	Why	Early revenue target
1	Direct sponsorships	Fastest meaningful cash; does not require massive traffic	40%
2	Affiliate guides	Compounds over time and fits AI/software/hardware coverage	35%
3	Premium membership	Recurring revenue, but only after benefits are real	20%
4	Listings / reports	Good later; avoid distracting yourself now	5%

2. The exact products to sell

Keep the commercial menu small enough that you can explain it in one minute.

A. Sponsor products - the fastest route to cash

Offer	Starting price	Deliverables	Buyer
Starter sponsor	\$250	Logo + short sponsor message in one newsletter or weekly briefing	Young AI/SaaS startup
Launch package	\$500	Sponsored launch post + homepage placement for 3 days + newsletter inclusion	New app, AI tool or hardware product
Monthly partner	\$1,000	Four newsletter placements + category banner + one magazine placement	Growing SaaS, security or hardware brand
Magazine presenting sponsor	\$500-\$1,500	Brand on cover/intro page + 2 interior placements + launch distribution	Design-forward technology brand

- Start at the low end until you have traffic, email, click and engagement proof.
- Sell packages, not random banner impressions. A small company understands a launch package; it does not care about complicated media jargon.
- Label paid material clearly as Sponsored and never promise positive editorial coverage.

B. Affiliate products - articles that can earn repeatedly

- Best AI tools for a specific job: writing, coding, research, meetings, video, local models.
- X vs. Y comparisons: ChatGPT vs. Claude, cloud GPU services, VPNs, password managers, newsletter platforms.
- Hardware buying guides: local-AI laptops, GPUs, workstations, monitors, keyboards, microphones and creator gear.
- Tutorials that naturally require a product: how to run a local model, create an AI newsletter, secure a remote team, or build an AI workstation.

Affiliate rule

Every buying guide must solve a real reader problem. Put a plain disclosure near the recommendation, track outbound clicks, and update important guides monthly.

C. Reader membership - sell a product, not sympathy

Tier	Price	What the reader receives
Free	\$0	All normal news, limited magazine previews, free newsletter
Premium	\$4.99/mo or \$39/yr	Monthly magazine, daily no-fluff AI brief, audio, topic alerts, archive, fewer ads
Founding annual	\$29 first year	Premium benefits + founder badge + locked renewal discount; first 200 members only

Do not launch Premium until you can reliably deliver the magazine and briefing every month. A paywall without a product will slow growth and create cancellations.

3. How the website must be geared for revenue

The site should guide every visitor toward one of three actions: subscribe, click a recommendation, or advertise.

Site area	Exact change
Top navigation	NEWS MAGAZINES BEST AI TOOLS DEALS DAILY BRIEF ADVERTISE
Homepage hero	One primary story plus a permanent email signup: “The five AI developments worth knowing today.”
Article ending	Only one primary CTA based on article type: newsletter, related buying guide, or premium magazine.
Commercial hub	Create /advertise with simple packages, starting prices, audience description and contact form.
Affiliate hub	Create /best-ai-tools and /buying-guides; group content by problem, not random products.
Magazine page	Show issue covers, preview pages, benefits, sponsor availability and membership CTA.
Trust pages	Editorial policy, AI-use policy, corrections, affiliate disclosure and sponsored-content policy.
Analytics	Track newsletter signups, sponsor-form submissions, affiliate clicks, paid conversions and returning visitors.

Most important conversion asset

The free email briefing is more valuable than an anonymous pageview. Put the signup box on the homepage, inside articles, at article endings and on the magazine page.

The content system should publish three kinds of content

Type	Examples	Purpose	Publishing share
Traffic content	Fast news, explainers, launch coverage	Attract visits and create daily habit	60%
Money content	Reviews, comparisons, buying guides, deals	Generate affiliate clicks and sponsor interest	25%
Authority content	Magazine features, investigations, trend reports	Build trust and convert members/sponsors	15%

Do not allow the automated system to produce 95% short news and 5% everything else. High volume can make the site look active, but the money pages and flagship magazine create commercial value.

4. Your weekly operating system

This is designed to be manageable with the automated newsroom doing most production work.

Cadence	Work	Founder time
Every day	Publish 3-5 strong news items; send one concise daily briefing; check errors and broken images/audio	45-60 min human review
Monday	Choose one money topic and one magazine/authority topic for the week	30 min
Tuesday	Publish or update one comparison/buying guide with affiliate tracking	60-90 min
Wednesday	Contact 5 potential sponsors; follow up with previous leads	45 min
Thursday	Publish one review/tutorial and create social clips/cards from the best stories	60 min
Friday	Contact 5 more sponsors; check analytics; update the highest-clicked guide	60 min
Monthly	Release one premium magazine; create a sponsor results report; prune low-value content	Half day

The AI agents should handle

- Source monitoring, draft preparation, metadata, internal links, newsletter assembly, social variations and magazine layout drafts.

You must personally handle

- Final editorial approval, sponsor relationships, commercial pricing, product recommendations, disclosures and the weekly analytics decision.

Solo-founder advantage

Automation should reduce production labor so you can spend your limited human time on the two things agents cannot replace: trust and sales.

Simple sponsor outreach message structure

1. Name one recent product launch or campaign from the company.
2. Explain that RTFCLMGZN reaches AI/technology readers through articles, a visual magazine and a briefing.
3. Offer one fixed package with a clear price, not a long menu.
4. Show a mock placement or example page.
5. Ask for a 15-minute call or permission to send the one-page media kit.

5. The first 30 days

Execute in this order. Do not build advanced features before the commercial basics exist.

Timing	Action	Result
Days 1-3	Create Advertise, Affiliate Disclosure, Sponsored Content Policy and Email Signup pages	Commercially ready site
Days 4-7	Add conversion tracking and the permanent Daily Brief signup modules	You can measure actions, not just visits
Days 8-14	Publish 5 high-intent guides and build the Best AI Tools hub	First affiliate inventory
Days 15-18	Build a one-page sponsor media kit and 3 fixed packages	Something you can sell
Days 19-25	Contact 25 relevant AI/SaaS/hardware companies; offer the \$250 Starter or \$500 Launch package	First sponsor conversations
Days 26-30	Release a free pilot magazine with a Premium waitlist and one sponsor slot	Proof of the paid product

Your first 10 money pages

- Best AI tools for solo business owners
- Best AI coding assistants
- Best local-AI laptops at three budgets
- Best GPUs for running local language models
- ChatGPT vs. Claude vs. Gemini for research
- Best cloud GPU services for small developers
- Best cybersecurity tools for a five-person startup
- Best newsletter platforms for publishers and creators
- Best microphones and cameras for AI content creators
- Best software stack for launching an AI startup

Publishing rule for money pages

One excellent guide that ranks, gets shared and converts is worth more than fifty generic news summaries. Update the top performers instead of endlessly creating duplicates.

6. Realistic revenue milestones

These are planning examples, not guarantees. The result depends on audience quality, outreach and execution.

Milestone	Example mix	Meaning
First \$100	One \$250 sponsor discounted to \$100 for a pilot, or several affiliate conversions	Prove someone will pay
First \$500	One Starter sponsor + affiliate income	Commercial offer is working
\$1,000/month	Two \$350 sponsors + \$200 affiliate + 20 members	Repeatable early model
\$3,000/month	Two \$750 sponsors + \$900 affiliate + 120 members	Strong solo side business
\$5,000/month	Three \$1,000 sponsors + \$1,200 affiliate + 160 members	Can fund contractors and growth
\$10,000/month	Sponsor retainers + meaningful affiliate traffic + 500-800 members	Requires a proven audience and system

Illustrative monthly model at 10,000 engaged visits

Source	Assumption	Revenue
2 small sponsors	\$350 each	\$700
Affiliate commissions	20 purchases x \$15 average	\$300
25 paid members	\$4.99 monthly	\$125
Total		\$1,125/month

Illustrative monthly model at 50,000 engaged visits

Source	Assumption	Revenue
3 sponsors	\$1,000 average	\$3,000
Affiliate commissions	100 purchases x \$18 average	\$1,800
200 paid members	\$4.99 monthly	\$998
Listings / magazine sales	Small supplemental revenue	\$400
Total		\$6,198/month

The key dependency

Traffic alone does not create this revenue. You need commercial-intent pages, an owned email audience, sponsor outreach and clear conversion tracking.

7. What not to do

These choices waste solo-founder time or damage the brand.

- Do not cover every possible technology topic equally. Own AI, future computing, software, hardware and cyber-future culture.
- Do not put a hard paywall over normal news while the brand is still growing.
- Do not rely on AdSense as the business model. Add light display advertising later as background income.
- Do not publish unrelated coupon, gambling, finance or generic shopping pages just to chase search traffic.
- Do not create five membership tiers. Use Free, Premium and Founding/Team only.
- Do not accept sponsors that make the site look deceptive, cheap or unsafe.
- Do not sell positive reviews. Sponsors can buy clearly labeled placement, never editorial conclusions.
- Do not automate final approval of recommendations, sponsored stories or sensitive news.
- Do not spend months building a job board, API or community before sponsor and affiliate revenue are proven.

8. The decision dashboard

Review these numbers every Friday. Everything else is secondary.

Metric	Initial target	Action if weak
Email signup rate	3%+ of visitors	Improve signup placement and offer
Returning visitor rate	25%+ monthly	Strengthen daily brief and topic series
Affiliate click rate	3%-8% on buying guides	Improve tables, CTAs and relevance
Revenue per money page	Rising monthly	Update winners; remove weak duplicates
Sponsor leads	10 qualified outreaches/week	Maintain consistent founder sales
Sponsor close rate	10%+ after qualified conversations	Improve package and proof
Paid conversion	1%-3% of engaged email readers	Improve premium product, not pressure
Monthly member churn	Under 5%	Deliver the magazine and briefing reliably

Your 90-day objective

Build a machine that can repeatedly create: 10 sponsor conversations per month, growing affiliate clicks from evergreen guides, and a waitlist of readers asking for the premium magazine/briefing.

9. The simplified RTFCLMGZN money blueprint

Keep this page visible while operating the business.

Free product	Fast, visual AI/technology news plus a useful daily email briefing.
First money	Sell \$250-\$500 sponsor packages directly to AI, SaaS, cybersecurity and hardware companies.
Compounding money	Publish high-intent AI tool and hardware guides with affiliate links.
Recurring money	Sell Premium at \$4.99/month or \$39/year after the monthly magazine and daily intelligence product are dependable.
Weekly founder focus	Approve quality, publish two money pages, contact ten sponsors, review conversion data.
90-day success	At least one recurring sponsor, affiliate conversions every week, 500+ email subscribers and the first paid members.
Long-term expansion	Featured directory listings, job posts, team plans, sponsored reports and licensing - only after the core three engines work.

Bottom line

RTFCLMGZN does not need millions of visitors before it can earn money. It needs a clear commercial offer, content that helps readers make buying decisions, an email habit, and consistent outreach to technology companies. Build those in that order.

Research basis

The Verge's freemium model keeps core news free while charging for premium reporting/newsletters and a better experience: [The Verge subscription announcement](#)

Direct audience habits such as topic follows, personalized feeds and daily digest email: [The Verge audience engagement update](#)

FTC guidance says material brand relationships should be disclosed clearly and placed where people will see them: [FTC Disclosures 101](#)